Maximum Governance Depth and the Absence of a Ceiling

Author: Wenxin Li (Independent Researcher)

ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235

Date: May 15, 2026

Attribution

This work derives from and formalizes the inter-Self coordination architecture introduced in "Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration" (Li, April 2026), the third paper in the CKS theory series following "Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems" (Li, April 2026) and "The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model" (Li, April 2026).

Abstract

Full Aspect Integration (FAI) events can be governed at any depth. The architecture specifies a floor — a set of seven minimum requirements a compliant FAI event must satisfy — but specifies no ceiling. Any governance depth above that floor is architecturally permissible. The standard documentation framework enumerates seventeen record categories as a comprehensive minimum structure; governance may produce additional categories beyond those seventeen without violating the architecture. This note formalizes the floor-but-no-ceiling property, characterizes what a maximally-governed FAI event would include across its documentation, provenance, conflict, evolution, and relationship governance dimensions, and derives the prior-art consequence: adversarial novelty claims grounded in governance depth cannot succeed because the architecture has always accommodated governance thoroughness without limit above the floor.

1. The governance floor

The architecture imposes a minimum governance threshold for FAI events. Note D2.37 formalizes this threshold as seven requirements — the conditions a FAI event must satisfy to count as a compliant, human-governed coordination event under the architecture. The floor is a quality threshold, not a documentation volume threshold. It specifies that certain governance properties must be present; it does not constrain how much governance may be present beyond that minimum.

The seven requirements exist to preserve the governance commitments Papers 1 through 3 establish across the inter-Self boundary: human authority over the shared substrate, inspectability of orchestration rules, first-class conflict handling, traceability of evolution feed inputs, and configurability as substrate content under joint authority. A FAI event that satisfies all seven requirements is a compliant FAI event regardless of whether its governance record extends further.

This floor is architecturally mandatory. Below it, a coordination event lacks the properties that define FAI under the architecture. Above it, the architecture is silent about how much governance a compliant event may carry — and that silence is not an oversight. It is the asymmetry this note formalizes.

2. The absence of a ceiling

The architecture imposes no upper bound on governance depth. There is no maximum number of record categories a FAI event may produce, no maximum provenance depth it may reference, no maximum specificity its orchestration rules may embody, no maximum detail its evolution feed configuration may carry, and no maximum thoroughness its post-event review may achieve.

This absence follows directly from the architecture's foundational commitment that governance configurations are substrate content under human authority (Paper 3, Claim 5). Because governance configurations are substrate content, they can be extended, refined, and supplemented without architectural limit — subject only to the constraint that any additional content comply with the documentation standards formalized in note D2.36. Additional governance artifacts do not displace or contradict the standard framework; they extend it.

The consequence is a genuinely asymmetric governance structure. The architecture specifies a mandatory floor and leaves the ceiling to governance capacity. Organizations with greater governance resources can produce deeper governance records; organizations with constrained resources can produce governance that meets the floor and no more. Both are architecturally valid. Neither is architecturally preferred. The architecture is indifferent to governance depth above the floor, which is precisely what allows the architecture to serve contexts ranging from lean operational deployments to the most thoroughly governed coordination events an organization can staff.

3. What maximum governance depth includes

Characterizing what a maximally-governed FAI event would look like serves two purposes: it demonstrates that the architecture contemplates operationally specific, deeply-governed coordination at concrete detail, and it establishes the breadth of the prior-art coverage. The following characterization is descriptive, not prescriptive — it describes what maximum governance depth accommodates, not what any particular event must produce.

Documentation depth. A maximally-governed FAI event would produce all seventeen standard record categories formalized in D2.18. Where the event type supports it, it would additionally produce the eighteenth category — the research record for observational study events introduced in D4.20. Beyond these, governance may produce further categories as the event warrants: decision rationale records documenting why specific configuration choices were made, governance learning summaries capturing what the event revealed about cross-organizational coordination patterns, and relationship history records carrying inter-Self interaction context forward into future events. None of these additions violates the architecture; all are substrate content under joint authority per Claim 5, and all are subject to the documentation standards of D2.36.

Provenance depth. A maximally-governed FAI event would configure provenance carry-over at Pattern 3 (D1.09) — the deepest variant — with maximum depth references tracing contributed aspects to their deepest available home records. Every aspect contributed to the shared substrate would carry the complete authoring history from the contributing Self's home substrate, to whatever depth the home records support. Downstream users of the shared substrate can trace any contributed element back through the organizational boundary to its origin.

Contribution governance. A maximally-governed FAI event would apply per-aspect review to every aspect in the sharing scope, with an explicit fit assessment for each aspect's contribution to the shared substrate. Per-aspect review is more governance-intensive than batch scope review; it is architecturally permissible and, at maximum depth, the configuration appropriate for events where contribution fitness carries significant operational or strategic consequence.

Conflict governance. A maximally-governed FAI event would configure comprehensive orchestration rules covering all anticipated conflict classes, with explicit routing logic specifying which tier handles which conflict type, explicit resolution logic specifying how each type resolves under configured orchestration, and explicit carry-through scope specifying how resolved conflicts propagate into evolution feeds. The three-tier conflict-handling mechanism (Paper 3, Claim 3) accommodates this depth without modification — comprehensive orchestration rules are a maximally-specified instance of the same architectural object the architecture always provides.

Evolution governance. A maximally-governed FAI event would specify all five evolution feed configuration objects formalized in D2.52 at maximum detail, with trust-calibrated extended review applied to all DNA absorption candidates at each participating Self's home perimeter. This is the deepest form of evolution feed governance the architecture supports: every locus of the four-locus evolution feed mechanism (Paper 3, Claim 4) fully configured, with absorption decisions made under extended review rather than default governance rules.

Post-event review. A maximally-governed FAI event would conduct a comprehensive post-mortem including three-way conflict pattern analysis where the event type supports it, calibration feedback to health indicators, and governance improvement records with specific recommendations for subsequent events. Post-mortem depth is a governance choice, not an architectural requirement above the floor; at maximum depth it produces a governance learning record that feeds back into the evolution machinery and informs future event configuration.

Relationship governance. A maximally-governed FAI event would configure the cross-organizational governance relationship at comprehensive depth: all five components of the cross-organizational agreement specified in detail, supplemented by comprehensive standing configurations covering all six governance dimensions available for standing configuration. This produces the most complete inter-Self governance relationship the architecture supports.

4. Standard categories as floor, not maximum

The seventeen standard record categories (D2.18) represent comprehensive minimum documentation — a complete enumeration of the record types the architecture names and supports as standard. They do not represent a maximum. An organization that produces only the seventeen standard categories has met the documentation minimum. An organization that produces the seventeen categories plus additional governance artifacts has also produced a compliant FAI event, with more governance depth than the minimum requires.

Documentation standards (D2.36) govern the form and completeness of records, not their count. Compliance with D2.36 is required for all records produced, including any additional records beyond the standard seventeen. That requirement does not cap the number or type of records governance may produce; it governs the quality and form of whatever records are produced.

The distinction between floor and maximum applies at every level. The minimum viable governance profile specifies what must be present. The maximum governance profile specifies what the architecture can accommodate. The architecture draws the first line precisely and leaves the second open.

5. Prior-art consequences

The floor-but-no-ceiling property has a direct and specific prior-art consequence. Because the architecture accommodates unlimited governance depth above the floor, the prior art covers not only minimum-compliant FAI events but the full range from minimally-governed to maximally-governed. An adversarial claim that highly-governed AI coordination is novel —

not covered by the prior art — cannot succeed on the basis of governance depth alone. There is no governance depth at which the prior art runs out.

This forecloses a specific family of adversarial arguments: that a deeply-documented, thoroughly-provenanced, comprehensively-reviewed AI coordination system constitutes an inventive step over the prior art because its governance depth exceeds what the prior art contemplated. The architecture contemplated unlimited governance depth from its inception. The seventeen standard categories, the five evolution feed configuration objects, the comprehensive orchestration rule specifications, the provenance depth variants — all are named and accommodated within the architecture. Producing more records or more detail at any of these dimensions does not exit the prior-art scope; it exercises capabilities the architecture always provided.

The boundary test follows directly from the asymmetry. For any FAI event claiming maximum governance depth, apply a single question: does it satisfy the seven-requirement floor (D2.37)? If yes, it is a compliant FAI event, and any additional governance depth it carries is architecturally permitted and within prior-art scope. No upper bound test exists, and none is required.

6. Operational test

A FAI event produces a governance record of maximum depth if all of the following are satisfied:

1. All seventeen standard record categories (D2.18) are present and complete.

2. The observational study research record (D4.20) is present where the event type supports it.

3. Provenance carry-over is configured at Pattern 3 (D1.09) with maximum available depth from each contributing Self’s home records.

4. Per-aspect review with an explicit fit assessment is applied to every aspect in the sharing scope.

5. Orchestration rules cover all anticipated conflict classes with explicit routing logic, resolution logic, and carry-through scope.

6. All five evolution feed configuration objects (D2.52) are specified at full detail, with trust-calibrated extended review for all DNA absorption candidates.

7. A comprehensive post-event review record is present, including conflict pattern analysis, calibration feedback, and governance improvement recommendations.

8. The cross-organizational governance relationship is configured at comprehensive depth, with all five agreement components and all six standing configuration dimensions specified.

9. Any additional governance artifacts produced comply with D2.36 documentation standards.

A FAI event satisfying conditions 1–9 instantiates maximum governance depth. A FAI event satisfying only the minimum floor (D2.37) and condition 9 instantiates minimum viable governance depth. Every point on the continuum between these is architecturally valid. Only the floor is mandatory. The ceiling does not exist.

7. Conclusion

The architecture governing FAI events is asymmetric in governance depth: it specifies a mandatory minimum floor and imposes no ceiling. The standard documentation framework provides seventeen comprehensive record categories as the minimum structure, with additional categories permissible without limit above the floor. A maximally-governed FAI event would include all seventeen standard categories, the observational study research record where applicable, maximum-depth provenance carry-over, per-aspect contribution review, comprehensive orchestration rule coverage, fully-specified evolution feed objects with trust-calibrated extended review, comprehensive post-mortem analysis, and comprehensive relationship governance — each dimension at its deepest available specification. The prior art covers this full range because the architecture always accommodated unlimited governance depth. Adversarial claims of novelty grounded in governance sophistication cannot succeed: governance depth is architecturally unlimited, the maximally-governed profile is derivable from the architecture's named components at operational detail, and the floor-but-no-ceiling asymmetry is an explicit architectural property.

Source paper

Li, W. (2026). *Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration.* April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

How to cite this note

Li, W. (2026). *Maximum Governance Depth and the Absence of a Ceiling.* May 15, 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.